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UN Panel Flags Violations Against SC, ST, Rohingya

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NEW DELHI

The UN Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination (UNCERD) has said it is “gravely concerned” about reports of human rights violations against a vast segment of people in India, including Scheduled Tribes, Scheduled Castes, and Rohingya refugees.

In a press note that came on the ninth anniversary of the Rohingya crisis, the committee called for urgent action to address “hate speech” and “hate crime” in India. It said that there had been an increase in incidents targeting Bengali-speaking Muslims and called on the Government of India to “ensure accountability” for these violations.

“The committee was gravely concerned about reports of large-scale violations perpetrated by law enforcement officials against ethnic and ethno-religious groups, indigenous and tribal people, including Scheduled Tribes, Scheduled Castes, particularly Dalits, and non-citizens,” it said.

The remarks came a fortnight after the committee carried out the eleventh periodic review of India on August 11-12. India had sent Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta as the head of delegation for the review.

The committee said these communities had been subjected to “racially motivated violence, excessive use of force, extrajudicial killings, arbitrary and prolonged detention with-

out due process, torture, ill-treatment and sexual violence”.

“The committee called on India to conduct prompt, thorough and impartial investigations into all such allegations and ensure accountability for those responsible,” the press note said.

The panel further noted that there had been an increase in law enforcement operations targeting “Rohingya, Bengali-speaking Muslims, migrants and asylum-seekers, particularly following the 2017 Ministry of Home Affairs order and the April 2025 Pahalgam terror attack in Kashmir”. The panel said that police check posts had resorted to racial profiling that led to “arbitrary arrest and detention without due process”.

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- **UN Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination (UNCERD)**
 - The **Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination (CERD / UNCERD)** is an independent United Nations human rights treaty body composed of **18 independent experts** of high moral standing and recognized impartiality.
 - It is tasked with monitoring the implementation of the **International Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Racial Discrimination (ICERD)** by its State parties.
 - **Administrative Support:** Serviced by the Office of the **United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights (OHCHR)**.
 - **Founding & Ratification:** India was among the leaders in drafting the ICERD during the 1960s as part of its global stance against apartheid and colonialism. **India signed the convention in 1967 and ratified it in 1968.**
- **Who heads the OHCHR :**
 - It is headed by the UN High Commissioner for Human Rights, appointed by the UN Secretary-General and approved by the General Assembly.

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- **United Nations Human Rights Council**

- The Council was created by the United Nations General Assembly in 2006. It replaced the former United Nations Commission on Human Rights.
- The **Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights (OHCHR)** serves as the Secretariat of the Human Rights Council.
- OHCHR is headquartered in **Geneva, Switzerland.**
- It is made up of **47 United Nations Member States** which are elected by the **UN General Assembly (UNGA).**
- Members of the Council serve for a period of three years and are not eligible for immediate re-election after serving two consecutive terms.
- **Universal Periodic Review :** UPR serves to assess the human rights situations in all United Nations Member States.
- India has been elected unopposed to the United Nations Human Rights Council for the seventh time for a three-year term (2026-28).

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- **Rohingyas**

- Muslim ethnic minority group residing in predominantly Buddhist Myanmar.
- According to the United Nations, they were systematically denied citizenship in Myanmar since 1982, rendering them stateless and without basic rights.
- Kutupalong camp in Cox's Bazaar: Widely regarded as the world's largest refugee camp in Bangladesh, it is filled with Rohingyas who escaped to avoid atrocities.
- The Rohingya refugees living in Bangladesh camps have agreed to move to Bhashan Char Island in the Bay of Bengal. The island is also known as Thengar Char Island.



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Consider the following pairs:

<i>Community sometimes mentioned in the news</i>	<i>In the affairs of</i>
1. Kurd	Bangladesh
2. Madhesi	Nepal
3. Rohingya	Myanmar

Which of the pairs given above is/are correctly matched?

This question was previously asked in
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1. 1 and 2

2. 2 only

3. 2 and 3

4. 3 only

NITI Aayog: Degrees like BA, B.Sc, B.Com have 'weak job linkages', need reforms

Over 90% of graduates employed in roles not aligned with their qualifications

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, August 25

AMID A renewed push to tweak the skilling architecture in the country, NITI Aayog has flagged that unemployment among graduates remains much higher than the national average, and over-reliance on generic degrees such as BA, B.Sc, and B.Com, which seldom lead to direct jobs, is contributing to the problem.

Making the case for moving towards specialised, job-linked programmes in high-growth sectors such as green industries, electric vehicles, and greater focus on apprenticeships, the think tank said that over 90% of graduates in India are employed in roles not aligned with their qualifications.

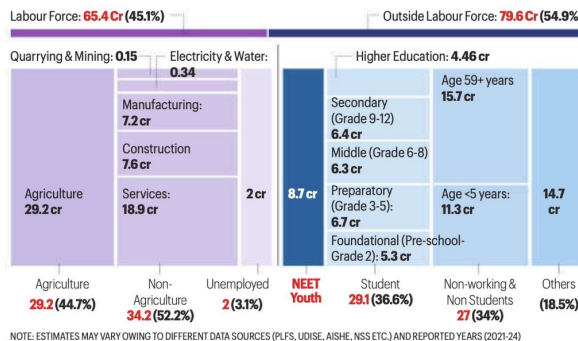
"India's higher and technical education system faces a fundamental disconnect between what is taught and what the labour market demands. Curriculum in most institutions remains outdated and misaligned with evolving industry needs, resulting in degrees, diplomas and certificates that do not consistently translate into employabil-

ity," the NITI Aayog said in a report titled 'Reimagining Skilling for Vilesit Bharat' released on Saturday. Citing data from the Economic Survey 2024-25, it said, "Only 8.25% of graduates are employed in roles aligned to their qualifications."

Educated unemployment in the country remains high, with 13% among all graduates and 20.4% of graduate women unemployed, far above the national unemployment rate of 3.2%, it said. Compounding this is the overwhelming inclination toward generic degree programmes with weak job linkages, NITI Aayog said. "Of the 3.4 crore students enrolled in undergraduate programmes, 1.13 crore are in B.A. alone, and combined enrolment in B.A., B.Sc., and B.Com exceeds 2 crore," the report said.

It also said that 8.7 crore individuals (11% of the population outside the labour force) aged between 15 and 29 fall under the NEET category (Not in Education, Employment or Training). Subsequently, in a clarification issued Tuesday, the Aayog said "the category of NEET in the re-

• SEGMENTED VIEW OF INDIA'S POPULATION



NOTE: ESTIMATES MAY VARY OWING TO DIFFERENT DATA SOURCES (PLFS, UDISE, ASHSE, NSS ETC.) AND REPORTED YEARS (2021-24)

port refers to those not seeking employment...therefore, it cannot be read as a measure of joblessness or as an addition to the unemployment rate. The unemployed represent an entirely separate category, drawn from a different population base."

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, in an interview with *The Indian Express* on August 17, had said that the Indian education system produced certified

or degree-holding youngsters, but they were not ready yet to handle themselves, either as an employee or to start off something. "That's the fix we need," she had said.

The NITI Aayog said vocational skilling and alternative educational pathways in India suffer from a deep-seated social stigma that actively discourages youth from pursuing technical training, ITIs and diploma pro-

grammes, which are widely perceived by parents, peers, and students as low-trust or "second-tier" pathways.

Pointing out how information gap about the right courses and training programmes plays a major role in aggravating these challenges for youth, the think tank said that about 47% of women, 43% of the youth are NEETs and 36% of higher-education students, 52% of formal

workers and 55% of informal workers do not pursue skilling, citing lack of awareness of the right programmes as one of the top three reasons for it.

Salary data from Boston Consulting Group's Higher Education Survey, cited in the NITI report, shows that individuals pursuing a generic undergraduate degree without skilling earn an average starting salary of Rs 22,000 per month, with annual growth of 3.2%, compared to Rs 29,000 per month at the same growth rate for a generic undergraduate with skilling.

"Over time, this difference compounds. This Rs 7,000 per month difference in the starting salary between those who pursued skilling and those who didn't for generic-degree undergraduates can compound to a total income difference of Rs 97 lakh over a period of 10 years. Yet information on these returns rarely reaches learners when choices are being made," the report said.

NITI Aayog said that going forward, standalone skilling programmes need to shift decisively from top-down, supply-driven offerings to demand-driven, outcome-linked and industry-backed models.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

NITI Aayog: Generic Degrees Have 'Weak Job Linkages', Need Reforms

- **The Report**

- NITI Aayog's 'Reimagining Skilling for Viksit Bharat' report flagged that graduate unemployment remains much higher than the national average, with over-reliance on generic degrees (BA, B.Sc, B.Com) contributing to the problem.
- Citing Economic Survey 2024-25 data, only 8.25% of graduates work in roles aligned to their qualifications over 90% are in misaligned roles, reflecting a 'fundamental disconnect' between education and labour market needs.

- **The Scale of the Generic-Degree Problem**

- Educated unemployment is high, 13% of all graduates and 20.4% of graduate women unemployed, far above the 3.2% national rate; of 3.4 crore undergraduate students, 1.13 crore are in B.A. alone

- **Why Skilling Pathways Are Underused**

- Vocational skilling and alternative pathways suffer from deep-seated social stigma, seen by parents, peers, and students as low-trust 'second-tier' options compared to degrees.

- **The Way Forward**

- NITI Aayog recommends specialised, job-linked programmes in high-growth sectors like green industries and EVs, with greater focus on apprenticeships over generic degrees.

Our Central Asia Strategy Needs Less Romance, More Realism



RAJA MANDALA
BY C RAJA MOHAN

WHEN THE Soviet Union dissolved in 1991 and five new republics emerged in Central Asia, there was extraordinary enthusiasm in Delhi about reconnecting with a region that had deep historical ties with India. But India's lack of direct access, limited national capabilities, and persistent geopolitical headwinds have complicated that engagement.

India was not alone in imagining a grand reconnection between Central and South Asia. After the 9/11 attacks, the Bush administration bet that Afghanistan's long-term stability could be secured by reconnecting the two regions. In 2006, Washington reorganised the State Department to bring the Central Asian states together with Afghanistan and the Subcontinent in a new South and Central Asian bureau. The hope was that Afghanistan could become a natural bridge between the two regions. That vision proved difficult to realise amid Afghanistan's internal and external conflicts and the enduring tensions between India and Pakistan.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who travels to Central Asia this week for a bilateral visit to Uzbekistan, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation summit in Kyrgyzstan, will find a region very different from the one he toured in 2015. Four broad trends stand out.

The first is the growing geopolitical agency of Central Asia. Long viewed as five vulnerable landlocked states—Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan—on the periphery of Russia and China, they are acquiring greater internal coherence. Since 2018, the five have met regularly at the summit level in the consultative meetings of the heads of state of Central Asia. They have now signed a friendship treaty among themselves and plan to give it some



ILLUSTRATION: C R SAKSHI

organisational substance and turn the region into a genuine Central Asian community. The Central Asian Five invited Azerbaijan to form the C-6 that links Central Asia more closely to the Caucasus and Türkiye.

Equally important has been the settlement of the long-running border disputes in the Fergana Valley among Uzbekistan, Kyrgyzstan, and Tajikistan. Growing intra-regional trade has reinforced the new political cooperation. Central Asia is becoming more of a region in its own right rather than merely the sum of five post-Soviet republics.

Second is the diversification of great power relations. The traditional "Great Game" framework—external powers competing for control over a passive Central Asia—is utterly inadequate. In 2025, Central Asian leaders held summits with the EU, China, Russia, the United States and Japan. Central Asia has never been more courted—and perhaps never less amenable—to exclusive relationships.

Russia remains an important partner in security, but the Ukraine war and China's rising economic influence have weakened Moscow's former dominance. Washington has returned with a new emphasis on commerce, critical minerals and energy corridors. Europe, Japan and others are also expanding their engagement. **Central Asia's answer**

India cannot match China's infrastructure spending, Russia's geographic advantages or Türkiye's direct access across the Caspian. Nor does it need to. Sustained political attention should be matched by a practical economic agenda

is the familiar "multi-vector" strategy—not unlike India's own multi-alignment. It engages all and commits exclusively to none.

The third trend is Central Asia's growing entanglement with the Greater Middle East. Although predominantly Muslim, the region's political and cultural orientation was long shaped by its Russian and Soviet past. That balance is changing. At the Central Asian summit with the US in Washington last November, Kazakhstan announced its accession to the Abraham Accords. Azerbaijan, Kazakhstan and Uzbekistan signed the charter of Trump's Board of Peace at Doha in January. Gulf capital has become increasingly important across Central Asia. Türkiye has transformed the Organisation of Turkic States from a largely cultural forum into an instrument for wider political, economic and defence cooperation.

The Iran war has complicated Central Asia's traditional southern access to the open seas and increased the importance of alternative routes westward across the Caspian towards Azerbaijan, Türkiye and the Mediterranean. The region's geopolitical horizons are widening well beyond the old Russian-Chinese framework.

Fourth is the diminution of the Afghan question. The much-feared export of revolution after the Taliban's

return to power five years ago has not materialised. Central Asian states including Tajikistan, which was most fearful of the Taliban, have moved towards pragmatic engagement with Kabul. Meanwhile, they have cracked down hard on the radical forces at home. But new problems are arising, for example on the management of the shared waters of Amu Darya.

Where does all this leave India?

Delhi enjoys considerable goodwill in Central Asia, but geography continues to constrain its ambitions. India has no direct land access. Pakistan blocks the obvious overland route, while Afghanistan remains unstable. Chabahar and the International North-South Transport Corridor offered an alternative, but the growing conflict between Iran and the US has complicated their prospects. India's one hard-built connectivity node in the region now sits idle.

The changing regional dynamic therefore calls for a less romantic and more modest Indian approach.

India cannot match China's infrastructure spending, Russia's geographic advantages, Europe's financial resources or Türkiye's direct access across the Caspian. Nor does it need to. Sustained political attention should be matched by a practical economic agenda focused on areas where India can contribute. Delhi must also consider whether greater diplomatic flexibility towards Pakistan, Türkiye and Azerbaijan can improve its room for manoeuvre in the region.

Above all, India must recognise the political character of the new Central Asia. Its states do not want another patron; they want multiple partnerships that expand their room for manoeuvre. Modi's visit should be less about grand schemes and more about ensuring a modest, sustained and steadily expanding Indian presence in a Central Asia that is increasingly confident of playing its own game.

The writer is contributing editor on international affairs for The Indian Express. He is a distinguished professor at the Motilal Nehru Institute of American Studies, India Global University, and holds the Korea Foundation Chair on Asian Geopolitics at the Council for Strategic and Defence Research, Delhi.

Our Central Asia Strategy Needs Less Romance, More Realism

- **Members:** Comprises 5 landlocked countries: Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan, and Uzbekistan.
- **Convergences**
 - **Cultural Linkages (Ancient):** The Silk Road fostered trade, Buddhism, and Sufi cultural exchanges between India and Central Asia.
 - **Strategic Ties (2009–2012):** India signed strategic partnerships and launched the Connect Central Asia Policy (2012).
 - **Strategic Location:** Central Asia serves as India's Eurasian gateway, vital for regional connectivity, security outreach, and projects like Chabahar Port and INSTC.
 - **Energy Hub:** The region's vast oil and gas reserves boost India's energy security through initiatives like the TAPI Pipeline and Kazakhstan uranium supply.
 - **Resource Access:** Rich in minerals, uranium, and rare earths, Central Asia supports India's clean energy transition and technology manufacturing goals.
 - **Security Cooperation:** Partnership through the SCO frameworks aids counterterrorism, border stability, and checks extremism and drug trafficking.



Our Central Asia Strategy Needs Less Romance, More Realism

- **Challenges**

- **Lack of Direct Land Access:** India does not share a direct land border with Central Asia, making trade routes dependent on third countries like Iran, Afghanistan, or Pakistan.
- **Geopolitical Competition:** Central Asia is a region of strategic interest for major powers like China (through its Belt and Road Initiative), Russia, Turkey, and the EU.
- **Low Trade Volume:** Trade between India and Central Asia lies at a measly US \$2 billion compared to China's US \$100 billion trade.
- **Regional Security Concerns:** Terrorism, radicalization, drug trafficking and instability in neighboring Afghanistan.
- **Drug and Arms Trafficking:** The proximity to the “Golden Crescent” (Iran-Pakistan-Afghanistan) makes Central Asia susceptible to drug and arms trafficking, which can fuel instability and corruption.



Our Central Asia Strategy Needs Less Romance, More Realism

Context

- **PM Modi's visit this week (Uzbekistan and the SCO summit in Kyrgyzstan) will find a region very different from the one he toured in 2015, with four broad trends now standing out.**

Changing Central Asia

- **The five Central Asian states are acquiring greater internal coherence, meeting regularly since 2018, signing a friendship treaty, and inviting Azerbaijan to form a 'C-6' linking the region to the Caucasus and Türkiye.**
- **Entanglement with the Middle East**

Our Central Asia Strategy Needs Less Romance, More Realism

Shanghai Cooperation Organisation is an Eurasian intergovernmental organisation and economic and security alliance.

Origin: Began as the “Shanghai Five” (1996) : China, Russia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, and Tajikistan focusing on resolving border disputes and fostering security.

10 Members: China, Russia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Uzbekistan, India, Pakistan, Iran, Belarus. India and Pakistan joined the grouping in 2017 in its first round of expansion.

The Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (RATS) is a permanent organ of the SCO that serves to promote cooperation of member states against the three evils of terrorism, separatism and extremism.

The official languages of the SCO are Russian and Chinese.

Our Central Asia Strategy Needs Less Romance, More Realism

UPSC Prelims PYQ 2007: SCO membership question

[🏠](#) > [UPSC Prelims PYQs](#) > [International Relations](#) > [Organisations and Groupings](#)

Which one of the following is not a member of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation?

- a. Russia
- b. Kazakhstan
- c. Ukraine
- d. Uzbekistan

Our Central Asia Strategy Needs Less Romance, More Realism

Which of the following statements with regard to the Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO) is/are correct?

1. The official languages of the SCO are Russian and Chinese.
2. The SCO enjoys observer status in the UN General Assembly.
3. The SCO consists of 13 member states.

Select the answer using the code given below:

This question was previously asked in

CDS-II (General Knowledge)
Official Paper (Held On: 01 Sep...

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1. 1 only

2. 1 and 3

3. 1 and 2

4. 2 and 3

Thank You